Campaign Face–off

How the two key adversaries are framing the Bengal contest

	TMC	BJP
CORE NARRATIVE	Bengali "asmita" (identity/ pride), federal pushback	"Paribartan" (governance reset), anti-corruption
LEADERSHIP PROJECTION	Mamata Banerjee as "protector" of Bengal against an overbearing Centre	Suvendu Adhikari as "giant slayer", challenger to Mamata
ORGANISATION MODEL	Grassroots network and I-PAC-backed micro-management	Centralised; cadre backed by over 700 external organisers
ADVERSARY POSITIONING	Questioning the BJP and the ECI on poll neutrality	The TMC as a corrupt, misgoverned party
MINORITY STRATEGY	Protect minorities, oppose Uniform Civil Code (UCC)	Split Muslim vote, implement UCC
WELFARE PROMISES	Incremental: ₹1,500–1,700 per month for women and unemployed youth (Lakshmir Bhandar, Yuva Sathi), doorstep health camps etc.	Higher payouts: ₹3,000 per month to women and youth, job push, 7th Pay Commission in 45 days, clearance of DA dues

Big Guns Blazing

Leaving nothing to chance, the BJP high command itself has stepped into the fray closer to the election. Some 500 rallies across 152 constituencies have been planned for the first phase on April 23. PM Modi is asking the Bengali electorate to give the BJP a chance. "Over the past several decades, Bengal has trusted many parties," he says. "They all betrayed the people. The BJP has the strongest track record." Home minister Shah has spent nearly 15 days in the state, his visits tightly mapped across North Bengal, Jangalmahal, the border districts and the industrial belt. He is said to have set a target of 170 seats, though in public he is promising an 'absolute majority'. The party has even borrowed Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath, who has asserted that only Bengali will be spoken in Bengal, Urdu speakers must go back home.

In a departure from the past, the BJP has also decided to refrain from making direct personal attacks against Mamata. In 2021, she had converted them into political capital, campaigning with an injured leg and a 'Khela Hobe' dare. This time, the BJP is appealing for change, encapsulated in its slogan, "*Paltano dorkar, chai BJP sarkar* (West Bengal is asking for a change, it wants BJP rule)". It is promising more doles, clearing dearness allowance dues, implementing the 7th Pay Commission within 45 days, relaxing the age criterion for job aspirants, and even proposing the Uniform Civil Code, an initiative that the TMC was quick to portray as a threat to minority rights in the hope of consolidating their vote. Abhishek also countered Shah's assertion that it is better to be ruled by Delhi than by Bangladesh, asking why the Centre then continues to shelter Sheikh Hasina.

Suvendu remains the party's strongest voice, and his duel with Mamata is central to this election. His candidature from Nandigram and Bhabanipur is intended to engage Mamata in a two-front battle. While she faces him directly in Bhabanipur, in Nandigram, the TMC is fielding Pabitra Kar, a Hindutva-leaning local leader with a strong grassroots connect, who had switched to the BJP alongside Suvendu in 2020 but returned to the TMC on March 17.

The BJP is also hoping that its appointment of Samik Bhattacharya, an RSS-backed leader with a more *bhadralok* style of articulation and proximity to poet Shakti Chattopadhyay, will help soften the party's image. His oratory and legislative experience as a Rajya Sabha MP are expected to lend a touch of sophistication to the BJP's leadership in Bengal. Dilip Ghosh remains another significant internal figure. A former state president and key architect of the BJP's expansion in Bengal, he continues to wield influence, particularly as a contender within its leadership hierarchy.

The real battle, though, lies elsewhere. Both Mamata and Modi are asking Bengal to vote in their names, to treat them as the candidate in all 294 constituencies. Mamata has done it before, but it's a first for Modi in Bengal. As a counter, she asks: "Are you the prime minister of India, or the chief minister of Bengal?" If she wins, that dare will only ring louder for the BJP as the 2029 general election draws near. ■

— *with* **Anilesh S. Mahajan**